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By Bartosz Brzeziński · Sep 7, 2026, 6:00 AM · [View in your browser](#)

Europe is short of corn — and Ukraine desperately needs ways to get its grain to market. Yet some of the farmers best placed to cash in may be thousands of kilometers away, in the United States.

U.S. President Donald Trump has made selling more American farm goods abroad a centerpiece of his trade push. Now, for reasons that have little to do with tariffs or trade deals, Europe may be about to oblige.

Heat and scant rain have shriveled corn crops across parts of western and central Europe, leaving the bloc needing millions more tons of imports to feed its pigs, chickens and cattle. Ukraine, traditionally one of the EU's biggest suppliers, would ordinarily be one of the key starting points for buyers.

But a wave of Russian attacks on ports and civilian shipping in late July and early August has effectively shut down Ukraine's main Black Sea outlet . And moving huge quantities of cheap, bulky grain across Europe by road and rail is slow and expensive.

For Ukraine, the consequences go far beyond missing out on a few sales. Agriculture Minister Taras Vysotskyi told POLITICO that if the Black Sea route remains closed, at least 30 million tons of farm goods, worth more than \$10 billion, could go unexported.

"It could lead to up to a 5 percent decrease in GDP," Vysotskyi said.

That would be a major setback for an economy the International Monetary Fund expects to grow by just 1 to 1.6 percent this year. Without the money from selling this harvest, Vysotskyi said, Ukrainian farmers could leave as much as 7 million hectares unplanted next season.

The irony is that Europe suddenly needs much more corn, a market Ukraine has traditionally dominated.

The EU expects to import around 25 million metric tons of corn between July this year and next June, up from 19.3 million over the previous 12 months, after domestic production fell by roughly 10 million tons, according to Louise Bogey, a European Commission spokesperson for agriculture. Ukraine typically supplies around half of the bloc's imported corn, she added.

American corn was already gaining ground earlier this year, helped by a big U.S. crop and low prices. In July and August, it accounted for more than two-fifths of EU imports, ahead of Ukraine. Russia's ongoing squeeze on Ukrainian shipping could now send even more of Europe's new business toward U.S. growers.

Cheap corn, costly journey

But if Europe needs the corn and its neighbor Ukraine has it, why not simply move more of it overland?

The answer starts with an unglamorous fact about grain. It is bulky, not worth much per ton and moved in enormous volumes, making cheap transport essential.

Those economics have long pushed Ukraine toward the sea. Before the latest disruption, seaports handled around 90 percent of its agricultural exports, including much of the corn sold to buyers in Spain, Italy and the Netherlands.

"It was the cheapest way," Vysotskyi said.

Russian attacks have now brought agricultural exports through the ports of Greater Odesa to a de facto halt. Railways, roads and the Danube river are keeping some trade moving, but cannot replace the volumes normally carried by sea. In August, Ukraine exported only around a third of what it could have under normal conditions.

And the cost of those detours adds up fast. Ukraine's agribusiness association UCAB estimates that replacing sea transport adds about €41 for every ton moved. Across the volumes Ukraine needs to redirect, that would amount to more than €1.1 billion in additional transport costs.

And the geography is awkward. Many of the places now needing more corn are in western and central Europe, far from Ukraine and accustomed to having imported grain delivered by ship rather than hauled across the continent by truck or train.

The result can look almost absurd on a map. Corn from across the Atlantic can be easier to get to parts of the EU than grain from next-door Ukraine.

Alexander Döring, secretary general of FEFAC, which represents Europe's animal-feed industry, said buyers are looking mainly to North and South America to cover the expected jump in imports. His group sees little scope for Ukraine to supply much of the extra corn Europe needs.

For the White House, that could be the kind of trade win Trump has spent the past year seeking, and one that would come at a useful moment. His war with Iran has throttled shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, driving up fuel and fertilizer costs for U.S. growers and putting fresh pressure on a core Republican constituency.

But if American farmers win more of Europe's corn business, it will owe less to Trump's dealmaking than to a drought-hit harvest and Russia's war on Ukraine.

Good for pigs, less so for growers

For Europe's livestock farmers, more Ukrainian corn would nevertheless be welcome.

Miguel Ángel Higuera, director of Spain's pig producers' association ANPROGAPOR, described conditions for farmers as "terrible," noting they have been selling animals below the cost of production this year. More Ukrainian corn would help bring feed costs down, he said, and Spanish pig farmers would support higher imports.

But, he said, “it will not be enough.”

Cheap grain is good news if you feed it to pigs. It is rather less welcome if you grow it.

That divide has dogged EU farm politics since the early years of Russia’s full-scale invasion, when farmers in countries neighboring Ukraine blamed an influx of its crops for pushing down local prices.

Poland, Hungary and Slovakia still maintain unilateral restrictions on some Ukrainian agricultural imports. Flora Dewar, trade policy director at COCERAL, which represents European grain traders, said those measures fragment the EU’s single market and undermine the free movement of goods.

Kyiv, meanwhile, is searching for ways to get Black Sea shipping moving again.

Vysotskyi said Ukraine is exploring both diplomatic and military options to make the route safe, although discussions on a possible agreement remain too preliminary to detail. It is also working with Romania and Poland to push more grain through the Danube and overland corridors.

For now, though, Ukraine’s cheapest route to many of the European buyers who want its corn remains largely closed. Until that changes, American farmers may get business that, on a map at least, looks like it should be Ukraine’s.

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